THE U-BOAT WAR 1914–18

BRITAIN'S ROYAL NAVY was made inescapably aware of the threat posed by German U-boats on September 5, 1914, when U-21 sank the cruiser *Pathfinder* off eastern Scotland—the first warship ever sunk by a submarine-fired torpedo. Allied naval commanders were slow to face up to the full implications of this event, sometimes disastrously failing to provide large warships with protective destroyer screens. Laxness was eventually replaced by paranoia, with fear of submarines severely inhibiting the operation of surface fleets. The most effective role for U-boats, however, was as commerce raiders. In February 1915 Germany began sinking, without warning, merchant ships in the waters around the British Isles, a practice halted in the face of American protests, but resumed with a vengeance in 1917. U-boats based at Austrian ports in the Adriatic played havoc with Allied merchant shipping in the Mediterranean. The Allies tried various responses from creating anti-submarine barriers across the entrance to the Channel and the exit from the Adriatic to raids on U-boat bases in Belgium. They were inexplicably slow to adopt the best solution: a system of merchant convoys.

WORLD WAR I

SINKING OF ABOUKIR, CRESSY, AND HOGUE



Date September 22, 1914
Forces British: 3 armored cruisers; Germans: 1 submarine
Losses British: 3 armored cruisers; Germans: none

Location Southern North Sea

In September 1914, in the area known as the Broad Fourteens, between the Netherlands and Dogger Bank, a force of British submarines, destroyers, and armored cruisers was on permanent patrol. Their role was to block any attempt by German surface warships to interfere with communications between Britain and continental Europe across the Narrow Seas. The cruisers were obsolescent ships manned mostly by reservists and cadets fresh out of naval college. Their position in the southern North Sea was so obviously exposed that they had been sardonically dubbed the "Live Bait Squadron." By the third week of September heavy seas had led to the withdrawal of their destroyer screen, while the need of one of the cruisers for coaling left only three on patrol: *Aboukir*, *Cressy,* and *Hogue*.



Engine room bell from U-9
Following her surrender in 1918, the bell from the submarine U-9 was engraved with the names of the sunken British cruisers *Aboukir, Cressy,* and *Hogue*.

THREE BEFORE BREAKFAST

Around 6:00 a.m. on September 22, Lieutenant Commander Otto Weddigen, commanding the submarine U-9, sighted the cruisers steaming in line ahead. He dived to close for attack and fired a single torpedo at *Aboukir*. This struck home to such effect that the ship sank within 20 minutes. The captains of the other cruisers, assuming that *Aboukir* had run into a mine, stopped and sent out boats to pick up survivors. At 6:45 a.m. the submarine unleashed more torpedoes against *Hogue*, now a sitting target. The cruiser was struck amidships twice in quick succession, almost breaking her in half. The captain of *Cressy* belatedly attempted to flee, steaming away from the scene of disaster where his ship's boats were still collecting survivors. It was too late, however, for the U-boat immobilized *Cressy* with one torpedo, then sent it to the bottom with a second. There were men rescued from *Aboukir* by *Hogue*, then from *Hogue* by *Cressy*, who were sunk three times.



Weddigen medallion
This commemorative German medallion shows a sinking British cruiser, with a portrait of Otto Weddigen on the obverse.

Weddigen was awarded the Iron Cross for his exploit. He was killed in March 1915 when his submarine U-29 was rammed by the battleship *Dreadnought* in Pentland Firth.

> "SUBMARINES ARE UNDERHAND. UNFAIR. AND DAMNED UN-ENGLISH. THE CREWS OF ALL SUBMARINES CAPTURED SHOULD BE TREATED AS PIRATES AND HANGED."
>
> **SIR ARTHUR WILSON**, CONTROLLER OF THE ROYAL NAVY, 1901



Ready for patrol
Otto Weddigen and his crew pictured on board the submarine U-9. A month after sinking the *Aboukir, Cressy,* and *Hogue*, U-9 also sank the British cruiser *Hawke*.

WORLD WAR I

ATTACK ON THE JEAN BART



Date December 21, 1914
Forces French: 1 dreadnought; Austrians: 1 submarine
Losses French: none; Austrians: none

Location Otranto Strait, off southern Italy

Admiral de Lapeyrère, commanding the French Mediterranean fleet at the outset of World War I, was noted for his scorn of submarine warfare and conviction that battleships would be the key to victory. In December 1914 Lapeyrère's flagship, the dreadnought *Jean Bart,* was leading a sweep of the southern Adriatic when an Austrian submarine, U-12, hit the battleship with a single torpedo. The explosion missed the forward magazine and the ship's compartmentalized hull served to keep her afloat. Lapeyrère reached Malta safely, but the damage to one of its most modern warships was a severe shock to the French Navy.

WORLD WAR I

SINKING OF THE LUSITANIA



Date May 7,1915
Forces British: 1 passenger liner; Germans: 1 submarine
Losses British: 1 passenger liner; Germans: none

Location Off Old Head of Kinsale, Ireland

The luxury passenger ship *Lusitania* left New York for Liverpool on May. 1 She had more than 1,900 passengers and crew on board and a very small quantity of ammunition in her cargo hold. On the afternoon of May 7, *Lusitania* was sighted off southern Ireland by Walther Schwieger, commander of the submarine U-20. A single torpedo struck the liner amidships. The ship sank in 18 minutes, killing 1,198 people including 128 Americans and almost 100 children. The sinking was a propaganda disaster for Germany, contributing greatly to the eventual entry of the United States into the war on the Allied side.